

HP Color LaserJet 2840

The HP Color LaserJet 2840 was the only colour MFD we tested. This colour MFD is targeted at SoHo users that want to have laser quality printouts.

The footprint of the MFD is 49.8 x 53 cm, which is a little larger than the other MFDs. The software and driver installation part was a whole new experience: the first part of the installation introduces you to the MFD and its various components-how to use and take care of them. The installation was simple, but took about 15 minutes, which is a too long.

This MFD is packed with features to the gills. It featured 96 MB buffer memory that is upgradable to 224 MB with one 100-pin SD-RAM module. The interpolated scanner resolution is 19,200 x 19,200 dpi is the highest we have yet seen.

Various types of memory cards such as CompactFlash Type I and II, xD-Picture card, SecureDigital, MemoryStick, MemoryStick Pro, SmartMedia and MultiMedia Cards are supported. A 10/100 network interface is available for connectivity along with a 33.6 Kbps modem.

This CMYK printing MFD comes with four toner cartridges—one for each colour. The printer's monthly duty cycle is a huge 30,000 pages, putting it way ahead of all the MFDs that we tested.

We were disappointed by the average performance of the 2840 during our speed tests, though. The black text page was printed in 19.74 and 64.44 seconds in Normal and Best modes respectively. The combi-document also printed at a slow pace, and the photo printout in Best mode took 167.53 seconds—much higher than that taken by any other colour laser printer.

The text print quality was found to be very crisp and this MFD scores in this area. It took a minute-and-a-half to scan an A4-size colour photograph at 24-bit colour depth, which is not bad, but it isn't great either. The colour differentiation of the scanned IT8 card was also above average, which means that the scanner is good for scanning colour photographs. In the colour copying test, the colour copy was found to be almost identical to the source document. It took 41.15 seconds to copy the colour document.

The LaserJet 2840 comes with 1-year on-site warranty, and HP has a whopping 273 service centres in 104 cities. At Rs 69,990, this workhorse is surely worth considering.



ously, how fast the MFD's scanner could scan a test image. The clear winner here was the Samsung SCX-4216F, with a score of 6.7 seconds. The second-placed—only just—was the Lexmark X215 which logged a time of 7.47 seconds, followed by Samsung's SCX-4100 at 7.61 seconds.

The Canon was a disappointment here, taking an eternal 13 seconds to do the job. If your work involves bulk scanning, you might want to look elsewhere.

After speed, we came to our quality tests, and we were not surprised. The Canon scored much higher than the others. Scan quality was simply superb. The Samsungs tied for second spot and the Lexmark was last. We can conclude that if you don't scan too much, but want decent quality scans, you should opt for the Canon MF 3110.

SoHos sometimes require that a document be scanned and converted to a soft copy in a word processing application. An OCR application facilitates this and the output depends on the ability of the scanner to scan discrete characters in the document. In our OCR test, we tried to get these scanners to read a newspaper. The Canon and the Samsung SCX-4216F disappointed us, getting twice as many characters wrong as the Lexmark X215 and the Samsung SCX-4100, which tied for first place.

The single biggest use of an MFD is perhaps a

combination of scanning and printing, i.e., copying. That makes this next test rather important. As always, we judged speed and quality and noted the tradeoffs.

The Samsung SCX-4216F was the faster copier and churned out a page in 11 seconds, while the Lexmark X215 took 11.38 seconds. The Canon took 13.8 seconds, and the Samsung SCX-4100 took a whopping 23 seconds to copy our test document. This translates to about six copies per minute.

In terms of quality, though, the SCX-4216F was a wee bit ahead of the SCX-4100. The Canon and Lexmark tied for third spot.

Coming to warranty and servicing, we were surprised to see that only Canon gave a 2-year warranty; the others provided just 1-year. All MFDs except the Lexmark X215 provided on-site warranty; Lexmark, for some reason, decided it would only give a carry-in, which would make life difficult if the MFD breaks down. You would have to carry it to a service station, of which Lexmark has only 34 in India!

Remember that the running costs of a MFD are far more than the purchase cost. The Lexmark was the cheapest here, requiring only Rs 1.125 to print a page. Only marginally, though, as Canon's cost per page is Rs 1.165. Compare this to the most expensive printers, the Samsungs, which cost Rs 1.667 to print a page.

Conclusion

At the end of the tests, the undisputed *Digit 'Best Buy Gold'* winner was the Canon MF 3110, even though it lacked a Fax unit. This was because of its printing and scanning speed. One other thing in its favour was the low price—Rs 19,995—and the higher duty cycle of 15,000. If you do not intend to use the Fax, opt for the Canon MF 3110 without another thought.

Choosing the 'Best Buy Silver' was not an easy task—the Lexmark X215 and the two Samsung MFDs were separated by just over a single point. But the Lexmark had a Fax, which the slightly lower-priced Samsung SCX-4100 didn't; besides, the Lexmark was priced considerably lower at Rs 20,995, while the Samsung SCX-4216F is steeply priced at Rs 34,995. Also, the Lexmark's duty cycle of 15,000 surpassed the 10,000 of the Samsungs.

The Lexmark X215 was therefore the *Digit 'Best Buy Silver'*.



Canon MF 3110